

SUBIR HALDER



The Angst of Painter Didi

KOLKATA The well-heeled might not consider it much of a style statement to have a Rs 1-lakh Tata Nano in their garage, but how about a Rs 1-lakh Mamata Banerjee in their living rooms? The Trinamool Congress chief—who has also penned many Bengali books on herself—is currently holding the second exhibition of her paintings at the Ashutosh Hall of the Indian Museum in Kolkata. And the price of each of the 45 paintings,

significantly, is Rs 1 lakh, minus any surcharges that automobile buyers have to pay. Banerjee has not clarified whether the show is a reaction to the Nano launch in Delhi last week, but the price tag and the timing say it all.

Titled *Mamata: 25 Hours In A Day, Chapter Two*, the paintings with bold brush strokes and childlike simplicity explore themes closest to the politician-artist's heart—images of Goddess Kali at Kalighat and

DIFFERENT STROKES: Mamta Banerjee's art

people symbolising farmers and rural women. The Trinamool Congress symbol, a flower and grass shoots, appears in a variety of complicated avatars as flowers, paddy shoots, open fields and trees. The colours are vivid—bright greens, blues, reds, ochres, gold and silver.

Banerjee fell in love with painting three years ago, and has takers for her art—14 of the 45 works were sold on the first day. The proceeds go towards helping the homeless in Nandigram. The artist was unable to attend to her audience; hence, banners at the gallery give an insight into Banerjee the painter.

The Tata plant in Singur finds a mention under “My Biggest Asset”, where Banerjee talks about “the love and support of the people, particularly during my 26-day hunger strike”. About her as a painter, she writes, “I am no artist, just a vagabond dabbling with colours.” Profound images, and words to match.

by Swagata Sen

SIGNPOSTS

APPOINTED: Shiv Shankar Mukherjee, senior diplomat and ambassador to Nepal, India's new high commissioner to Britain. A 1971-batch IFS officer, he succeeds Kamlesh Sharma.

SUSPENDED: Former Haryana chief minister Bhajan Lal, 77, from the Congress for “anti-party activities” for the formation of a rebel party, the Haryana Janhit Congress.



CONFERRED: On Professor V.N. Rajashekharan, vice-chancellor of the Indira Gandhi National Open University, the presidential gold medal for his contribution to the fields of biopolymers and peptides.

CONFERRED: On violin maestro Lalgudi G. Jayaraman, the Lifetime Achievement Award by the Chennai Music Academy in recognition of his monumental contribution to Carnatic music over the last six decades.

VIS-A-VIS SUNIL GAVASKAR ICC's cricket committee chairman **versus** JOHN REID former New Zealand cricket captain

Indians want to know if it was a white man (Procter) taking the white man's (Symonds) word against that of the brown man (Tendulkar).



SAURABH SINGH

He should decide who he's working for. In his position he's not supposed to be on any side. He's supposed to be neutral.

EPILOGUE: In the midst of everything partisan, neutrality is not a virtue one can stick to.